STATIC SHOCK

PUZZLE PLATFORMER - GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT v1.0

A compact, high-definition pixel-art platformer built around one core fantasy: electricity is your health, your resource, your weapon, and the key to every level.

Genre	Puzzle Platformer / Light Action
Perspective	2D Side-Scrolling
Visual Target	64x64 or 128x128 high-detail pixel characters
Structure	Standalone levels with free backtracking inside each level
Primary Focus	Environmental electricity puzzles
Session Style	Short, replayable levels that increase in complexity

1. High Concept

Vision

Create a simple-to-understand but increasingly clever platformer where the player explores a contained stage, extracts electricity from the environment, carries and redirects charge, solves interconnected puzzles, survives enemies that can steal charge, and ultimately powers the exit mechanism.

Design Pillars

- **Electricity is everything.** Charge functions as progression resource, puzzle currency, combat power, and survivability.
- **Puzzle first.** Enemies exist primarily to disrupt routing, timing, positioning, and resource decisions rather than turn the game into a brawler.
- **Backtracking with purpose.** Players can move forward and backward through the entire level. Discoveries made later can change what is possible in earlier sections.
- **One clear finish line.** Each level has a final gate, machine, battery, portal, or similar objective. Solve the level, power it, and exit.
- **Complexity over grind.** Later levels become difficult by combining mechanics, not merely demanding larger amounts of electricity.

2. Core Gameplay Loop

- Enter a compact side-scrolling level and identify the powered exit or final objective.
- Explore the environment and locate usable electrical sources.
- Absorb electricity into the player's charge meter.
- Carry, spend, transfer, or redirect that electricity to manipulate the level.
- Open routes, move powered objects, activate switches, disable hazards, or expose new energy sources.
- Avoid or outmaneuver enemies that can damage the player and knock stored charge loose.
- Recover lost electricity when possible instead of permanently losing all progress.
- Accumulate or route the required power to the final objective.
- Activate the exit and complete the level.

3. Electricity System

Charge Meter

The player has a visible electrical charge meter. Instead of separating health and puzzle energy into unrelated systems, the game should strongly connect survival and electricity. Carrying more power makes the player more capable, but also gives enemies more to take.

Energy Sources

Sources can include streetlights, fuse boxes, generators, batteries, neon signs, vending machines, electrical panels, powered rails, transformers, vehicles, machinery, and special level-specific devices.

Energy Types

Later stages may introduce visually distinct charge types. For example, blue charge could power standard machinery while another frequency or polarity is required for specialized devices. Color must always communicate a consistent rule.

Spending Charge

Devices consume a fixed amount of charge or require a continuous connection. This creates decisions such as whether to spend power opening a shortcut now or save it for the final gate.

Charge Loss

When struck by certain enemies or hazards, part of the player's stored electricity bursts out into recoverable charge pickups. The player can chase and reclaim them before they disappear or become inaccessible. This turns damage into a temporary puzzle setback rather than a traditional health-only penalty.

4. Movement and Player Abilities

Core Movement

Run, jump, drop through appropriate platforms, climb or traverse contextual level elements, and freely backtrack.

Absorb

Pull electricity from a valid nearby source. Sources clearly change state after being drained.

Discharge

Send stored power into compatible machines, switches, gates, enemies, or environmental objects.

Carry

Hold charge while traversing the level. Some puzzles specifically challenge the player to transport electricity safely between distant points.

Future Unlocks

Possible later mechanics include electric dash, rail grinding, magnetized movement, temporary overcharge, chain transfer, polarity switching, remote arc activation, and electricity-based movement of conductive objects.

5. Level Structure

Format

Think of each stage as a traditional Mario- or Kirby-sized level with a puzzle objective layered across it. The player is not locked out of earlier sections simply because they moved right. The entire stage can function as one interconnected puzzle.

Example Level

The exit gate is visible but requires three units of charge. One nearby power source provides only one. Exploring farther reveals a crate blocking access to another source. A switch opens the crate route but itself requires electricity. The player must decide where to spend the first charge, unlock the route, defeat or bypass a charge-draining enemy, collect additional power, then return to the beginning and energize the exit.

Difficulty Curve

Early stages teach one concept at a time. Mid-game stages combine two or three previously learned rules. Late stages become multi-step electrical logic problems with enemies, timing, environmental hazards, alternate routes, and optional shortcuts.

6. Puzzle Vocabulary

- **Power Gates:** Require a specific amount or type of charge.
- **Conductive Crates:** Can be energized, moved, magnetized, or used to bridge circuits.
- **Switch Networks:** Change doors, platforms, rails, or electrical routing.
- **Temporary Circuits:** Stay active only while electricity is continuously supplied.
- **Charge Transport:** Carry energy from one side of the stage to another without losing it.
- **Source Sacrifice:** Draining one object may disable something else, forcing the player to choose an order of operations.
- **Timed Power:** A device remains energized briefly, creating traversal puzzles.
- **Polarity / Frequency:** Different electrical states interact with different objects.
- **Enemy Interference:** Enemies guard sources, drain the meter, ground the player, block routes, or steal loose electricity.

7. Enemies and Hazards

Purpose

Enemies should behave like moving puzzle pieces and pressure systems. Combat can exist, but the player's main question should be 'How do I solve this room while dealing with that thing?'

- **Drain Enemy:** Contact steals a portion of stored charge.
- **Grounded Enemy:** Creates an area where electrical abilities are weakened or disabled.
- **Charge Thief:** Collects electricity knocked out of the player, forcing pursuit.
- **Conductor Enemy:** Redirects arcs and can accidentally or intentionally become part of a circuit.
- **Patrol Enemy:** Creates timing windows around important switches or sources.
- **Environmental Hazards:** Water, exposed wiring, grounded surfaces, moving machinery, unstable transformers, and timed electrical surges.

8. Progression

Level Progression

Levels are discrete. Completing the powered exit ends the stage and advances the player to the next level or returns them to a world/map screen.

Mechanical Progression

New concepts are introduced gradually, then recombined. A late-game level should feel difficult because the player must understand the electrical ecosystem, not because the game simply asks for twenty identical pickups.

Optional Mastery

Levels can include bonus batteries, hidden routes, time challenges, no-damage goals, or efficiency medals for completing the circuit with minimal wasted charge. These are optional and should not obscure the primary objective.

9. Visual and Audio Direction

Pixel Art

High-definition pixel art with readable silhouettes, expressive animation, strong environmental lighting, and electric effects. A 64x64 character scale is a strong production-friendly starting point; 128x128 can be explored if the additional animation workload is justified.

Visual Language

Powered objects glow and pulse. Drained objects visibly go dark. Compatible sockets share recognizable shapes and colors. Electrical paths should be readable without relying on text.

Audio

Electricity should have tactile sound design: hums, crackles, capacitor whines, power-down thumps, relay clicks, and escalating audio feedback as the player approaches maximum charge.

10. UI / HUD

- Primary charge meter, always readable at a glance.
- Optional segmented display showing exact usable charge units.
- Context prompt only when needed for absorb/discharge interactions.
- Clear feedback showing how much electricity a device requires.
- Brief visual indication when lost charge can still be recovered.
- Minimal objective text; the environment should communicate most puzzle information.

11. Sample Early Level Roadmap

Level 1 - First Spark

Learn to absorb from a single source and spend it on the exit.

Level 2 - Split Decision

Two devices compete for limited power; one opens the route to the energy needed for the exit.

Level 3 - Don't Get Hit

Introduce an enemy that knocks charge loose. Teach recovery.

Level 4 - Carry Current

Transport electricity across a traversal section.

Level 5 - Power and Position

Move a conductive crate, energize a switch, and backtrack to the exit.

Level 6 - Grounded

Introduce an enemy or hazard that temporarily prevents electrical abilities.

Level 7 - Timed Circuit

Power a temporary platform route and race through before it shuts down.

Level 8 - Chain Reaction

Route electricity through multiple devices in the correct order.

Level 9 - Mixed Test

Combine transport, enemy interference, and a multi-stage gate.

Level 10 - First Major Finale

A larger stage that tests every core mechanic introduced so far.

12. MVP Scope

Goal

Build a polished vertical slice proving that the electricity loop is fun before expanding content.

- 1 playable character.
- Run, jump, absorb, discharge, damage/charge-loss, and recovery.
- 1 charge meter.
- 3 electrical source types.
- Gate, switch, movable conductive object, and one timed device.
- 2 enemy types: charge drainer and grounded patrol.
- 3 complete levels: tutorial, intermediate puzzle, and combined-mechanics finale.
- Pixel-art environment kit, basic VFX, UI, and core sound effects.

13. Success Criteria

- A new player understands within the first level that electricity is the central resource.
- Players can look at a puzzle and form a plan without needing constant text instructions.
- Taking damage creates tension without forcing repetitive full-level resets.
- Backtracking produces 'aha' moments rather than unnecessary walking.
- Each new mechanic can be combined with earlier mechanics to create many levels from a relatively small system set.
- The prototype is fun with placeholder content before large-scale art production begins.

14. IP / Production Note

Prototype Direction

This document follows the requested Static Shock-inspired game concept. If the project is intended for public release or commercial sale, Static Shock is an existing DC character/IP, so the production should either secure the necessary rights or convert the prototype into an original electricity-powered hero, world, names, and visual identity before release.

Core pitch: Explore. Steal the current. Solve the circuit. Protect your charge. Power the exit.